

Take Up Your Cross - Mark 8 (Handout)

Take Up Your Cross

A Group Study on Mark 8:31-9:1

And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again. And he said this plainly. And Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him. But turning and seeing his disciples, he rebuked Peter and said, "Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man." And calling the crowd to him with his disciples, he said to them, "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. For whoever would save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake and the gospel's will save it. For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul? For what can a man give in return for his soul? For whoever is ashamed of me and of my words in this adulterous and sinful generation, of him will the Son of Man also be ashamed when he comes in the glory of his Father with the holy angels." And he said to them, "Truly, I say to you, there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power."

A note about Mark: He wrote for Christians in Rome while Nero was crucifying believers and burning them as torches. When Mark wrote down *take up your cross*, his readers knew it was not a metaphor. Most of us will not be crucified — but the cross has a thousand shapes, and Jesus meets us on whatever road we are actually walking.

1. The Necessary Road (vv.31-33)

For the first time, Jesus tells his disciples plainly: *I am going to be killed — and after three days I will rise.* The small word "**must**" is important. In Greek, *dei* carries the weight of divine necessity — the cross is not an accident, it is the plan.

Peter cannot bear it. He pulls Jesus aside and tries to talk him out of it. Jesus' answer is shocking: "**Get behind me, Satan!**" Peter was not the devil — but his words came from the same playbook. Satan had already offered Jesus a kingdom without a cross in the wilderness. "Get behind me" literally means *get back in line* — you are my disciple, not my manager.

Sometimes the hardest thing about the cross is not the cross itself — it is the well-meaning voice that says, *Surely it doesn't have to be this way.* Some of that voice is love. Some is Peter. Jesus teaches us to know the difference.

Questions

1. Has anyone, out of love, ever tried to talk you out of something God was asking of you? How did you tell the difference?
 2. Jesus predicted his death *and* his resurrection in the same breath, but the disciples only heard the first half. How hard is it to remember both the cross and the rising when you think about the road ahead?
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2. Deny, Take Up, Follow (vv.34-37)

Jesus calls the **crowd** — not just the Twelve. Cross-bearing is for whoever will come. Three verbs, in order:

Deny yourself — not self-hatred, but taking the crown off your own head and putting it where it belongs.

Take up your cross — in the first century, this phrase had only one meaning: a condemned man carrying his own crossbeam to his execution. Today the cross is jewelry. For Jesus' hearers, it was a death sentence.

Follow me — in Greek, the first two verbs are decisive, once-for-all. But "follow" is continuous — day after day after day.

Then the paradox: *whoever saves his life will lose it; whoever loses his life for Jesus will save it*. The word is *psychē* — both your physical life and your true self. Spend your life protecting it, and you lose the self you were meant to be. Spend it for Christ, and you find it on the other side. *What can a man give in exchange for his soul?* Put the whole world on one side of the scale and one soul on the other, and the soul tips it.

Here is what is beautiful for this room. Many of you are already carrying a cross you did not choose — a body that aches, a spouse you buried, an independence you lost. *Jesus is already on this road*. The question is not whether you will carry it. You already are. The question is whether you will carry it **behind him**. Self-pity carries it alone. Faith carries it in his footsteps.

Questions

1. Many of you are already carrying a cross you did not choose. What would it look like to carry it *with* Jesus rather than alone?
 2. You have watched a whole generation chase after "the world." What have you come to understand about the worth of a soul?
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3. Not Ashamed, Kingdom Come (v.38-9:1)

The warning. *Whoever is ashamed of me... I will be ashamed of him when I come in my Father's glory.*

"Ashamed" meant disowning someone in public — refusing to use their name when others were watching. In our generation, Jesus' name gets easier to avoid every year. Many of you have felt it — you keep a Bible by your chair, but when conversation turns to real things, his name sticks in your throat. Jesus says: *Don't*. Not angry, not loud — just not ashamed.

The hope. *Some standing here will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power.* The Greek verb is perfect tense — not "about to come" but "already arrived, standing here in power." Six verses later, Peter, James, and John climb a mountain and watch Jesus transfigured — his face shining, the Father's voice from the cloud. They saw. Through the resurrection, Pentecost, and the Church, the Kingdom kept breaking in.

Many of you stand closer to the veil than most. The Kingdom has *already* come in power. The resurrection has *already* happened. You are not waiting for proof. You are waiting for the veil to lift — and when it does, you will find you did not see the half of it.

Questions

1. Where do you feel pressure to be quiet about Jesus? What would it look like to say his name, gently, in one of those places this week?

2. The Kingdom has *already* come in power. Where have you seen evidence of that across your lifetime?

For Reflection

This week: name one cross you are already carrying — something you did not choose and cannot change. Say it to the Lord, and pray: *Jesus, I am not carrying this alone. I am carrying it behind you.*

Then speak his name once in a place where silence would be easier. To a grandchild. To a nurse. To a friend at the table. You don't have to argue. Just say his name.

"There are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come in power."

Right here. Right now. For whoever will follow.